MCO-1D ORNITHOPTER

Complete Commissioning and Operating Manual

Bench Tests · TC-02 · TC-03 · Ground Station · First Flight

For personnel who are new to this project. Every step explained from first principles. Nothing assumed.

CONFIDENTIAL — Programme Document

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SECTION 1 — WHAT THIS AIRCRAFT IS AND WHAT IT DOES

1.1 The Basic Idea

The MCO-1D is an ornithopter — an aircraft that flies by flapping its wings, like a bird or a dragonfly, rather than using a propeller or jet engine. It has four pairs of wings (eight wings in total) that beat up and down continuously while in flight. The pattern in which the wings beat — how fast, how far, and with what timing between pairs — is controlled by a computer running software called the Wave Library.

Unlike a conventional aircraft where the engine produces thrust and the wings produce lift as separate functions, on the MCO-1D the flapping wings do both simultaneously. Flapping faster produces more lift and more thrust. Changing how far the wings travel on each stroke changes the aerodynamic character of the flight.

1.2 What Makes This Design Special

The wings beat in a specific pattern called a **metachronal cascade**. This means the four pairs do not all beat at exactly the same moment — each pair is slightly offset in time from the next. This is the same pattern used by dragonflies, which are among the most aerodynamically capable insects in nature. Dragonflies can hover, fly backwards, turn 180 degrees in three wingbeats, and achieve speeds up to 54 km/h. The MCO-1D is designed to replicate and extend these capabilities.

1.3 The Purpose — Search and Rescue

The MCO-1D is designed for Search and Rescue (SAR) operations. It needs to be able to: fly to a location quickly, hover or fly slowly over a target area while a camera searches, manoeuvre in confined spaces such as between buildings or in wooded terrain, and land or deploy equipment with precision. The combination of flapping-wing efficiency and the ability to fly at very slow speeds — capabilities that conventional drones cannot easily combine — makes it well suited to this role.

1.4 The Three Main Systems

Everything in this project falls into one of three categories:

- **Mechanical:** The wings, the fuselage structure, the sector wheels that drive the wing motion, the ropes and capstans, and the landing gear.
- **Electrical:** The battery, the motor controllers (called ODrives), the motors that drive the wings, the servo motors that control wing angle, the autopilot board (Pixhawk), and the load cells used for testing.
- **Software:** The Wave Library running on the Raspberry Pi, the ground station application on the laptop, and the autopilot firmware on the Pixhawk.

This manual covers all three in the order you need to work through them.

SECTION 2 — HARDWARE INVENTORY — EVERY PART LISTED

Before connecting anything, confirm you have every item in this list. If anything is missing, do not proceed — working with incomplete hardware can damage components.

2.1 Airframe Components

Wings	8 total (4 pairs). Each wing is built from carbon fibre spars and a membrane. Wings 1 and 2 are the largest (front pair), Wing 4 pair is the smallest.
Fuselage	The main body spine. All other components attach to this.
Sector wheels	8 total, one per wing. These are the disc-shaped mechanical components at each wing root that the rope wraps around to drive the flapping motion. Each has 200 degrees of total travel (±100 degrees from centre).
Ropes/Capstans	The mechanical link between the motor shaft and the sector wheel. Must be tensioned correctly.
Landing gear	Three-point wheeled undercarriage. Allows ground roll and taxi.
Wing root joints	The pivot point for each wing. Allows the wing to sweep (fold forward/aft) and change dihedral (tilt up/down).

2.2 Motors

Flap motors	8 × GoolRC 5010 360KV brushless motors. One per wing. These drive the flapping motion through the sector wheel. 360KV means the motor spins at 360 RPM per volt applied.
Motor purpose	The flap motors are the primary thrust and lift producers. They are the equivalent of the engine on a conventional aircraft.

2.3 Motor Controllers (ODrives)

An ODrive is a precision motor controller. It takes commands from the Raspberry Pi and converts them into exactly the right electrical signals to make the motor move to a specific position at a specific speed. Think of it as the interface between the computer (which speaks digital) and the motor (which speaks electrical current).

ODrive units	4 units, each controlling 2 motors (one per channel). Total: 4 ODrives × 2 channels = 8 motor channels.
Communication	CAN-FD bus. This is a high-speed digital communication standard, the same type used in modern cars. All 4 ODrives share a single cable pair running in a daisy-chain.
Power input	4S LiPo battery, approximately 14.8V. Each ODrive has its own power connection from the battery distribution board.

Key setting: vel_limit	Must be set to 150 rad/s before first flight. This is the maximum angular velocity of each motor shaft. Factory default is much lower and must be changed. Procedure in Section 8.

2.4 Servo Motors

Servo motors are small, precise positioning motors. They receive a pulse-width signal and move to a specific angle. Unlike the flap motors, servos do not spin continuously — they move to a commanded position and hold it.

Pitch servos	8 × Helidirect TORQ TCM-1001. One per wing. These rotate the wing chord to change the angle of attack — the angle at which the wing meets the air. Controls how much lift each stroke produces. Operate at 333Hz PWM signal, 7.4V supply.
Sweep servos	8 × DS3225-class servos. One per wing. These fold the wing forward or backward (sweep angle). Used to change the wing's shape for different flight modes. Operate at 50Hz PWM.
PWM signal	Pulse Width Modulation. The servo reads a signal that pulses between 1000 microseconds (full one direction) and 2000 microseconds (full other direction), with 1500 microseconds as neutral.

2.5 Flight Controller (Pixhawk)

The Pixhawk is the autopilot board. It contains an Inertial Measurement Unit (IMU) — a combination of accelerometers and gyroscopes — that measures the aircraft's attitude (which way it is pointing) and motion at all times. It also has a barometric altimeter, GPS, and communicates with the Raspberry Pi.

IMU	Measures roll (banking), pitch (nose up/down), and yaw (turning). Updates at 400Hz.
Barometer	Measures altitude by air pressure. Accurate to approximately ±3 metres.
GPS	Provides position, groundspeed, and heading. Requires clear sky view to acquire satellites.
Communication to Pi	Serial UART at 921600 baud, using MAVLink protocol.
Power	5V regulated, from the power module.

2.6 Raspberry Pi

The Raspberry Pi is the main flight computer. It runs the Wave Library software that controls everything. The Pixhawk provides sensor data; the Pi processes it and sends commands to the ODrives and servos. Think of the Pi as the pilot and the Pixhawk as the instruments.

Model	Raspberry Pi 4 (recommended) or Pi 3B+. Pi Zero 2W can work but needs USB-ethernet adapter.

Storage	MicroSD card, minimum 32GB, Class 10 or better. This holds the operating system and the Wave Library.
Power	5V, 3A minimum. Use the official Pi power supply or a quality USB-C supply.
GPIO pins	The 40-pin header on the Pi connects to the servo signal wires. Specific pin assignments are in Section 3.
Ethernet port	Used for laptop connection during testing. Direct cable to laptop — no router needed.

2.7 Load Cells (for TC-02 and TC-03)

A load cell is a precision force-measuring sensor. During the tethered thrust tests it measures exactly how much upward force the aircraft is producing. This is how we know whether the aircraft can carry its own weight.

Load cell type	HX711-based strain gauge load cell. Rated capacity must exceed the aircraft weight (34N minimum — recommend 50N or 100N rated cell).
HX711 amplifier	The HX711 is a small circuit board that amplifies the tiny signal from the load cell to a level the Pi can read.
Connection to Pi	Two GPIO pins: DT (data) on GPIO 26, SCK (clock) on GPIO 7. Four wires total (DT, SCK, VCC 3.3V, GND).
Mounting	The aircraft hangs or sits on the test rig. The load cell is between the aircraft and the fixed structure. As the wings produce lift, the force reading increases.

2.8 Battery

Type	4S LiPo (Lithium Polymer). 4S means four cells in series.
Voltage	Nominal 14.8V. Fully charged: 16.8V. Do not discharge below 14.0V (3.5V per cell).
Capacity	Recommend 4000-6000mAh for useful flight time. Larger = heavier = less performance.
Connector	XT60. The battery connects to the power distribution board which then feeds the ODrives, Pi, and Pixhawk separately.
WARNING	LiPo batteries are potentially dangerous if punctured, overcharged, or discharged too far. Always use a proper LiPo charger. Never leave charging unattended. Store in a LiPo-safe bag.

2.9 Laptop (for Ground Station)

Any laptop	Mac, Linux, or Windows. Must have Python 3.8 or later installed.

Ethernet port	Needed for direct cable connection to Pi. If laptop has no ethernet port, a USB-to-ethernet adapter works fine.
Software needed	Only Python 3.8+. The ground station application (mco_ground_station.py) uses only standard Python libraries — nothing to install.

SECTION 3 — ELECTRONICS WIRING — WHAT CONNECTS TO WHAT

■ BEFORE CONNECTING ANYTHING: Remove the battery. Work with power disconnected at all times until Section 10 (calibration) specifically instructs you to connect power. Connecting power to wired electronics can cause permanent damage.

3.1 Overview — The Signal Flow

Understanding signal flow makes the wiring logical. Here is the path a command takes from pilot input to physical wing movement:

- Pilot moves lever on transmitter
- Transmitter sends radio signal to receiver
- Receiver sends signal to Pixhawk
- Pixhawk sends sensor data to Raspberry Pi (via serial)
- Raspberry Pi runs Wave Library, computes wing commands
- Pi sends position commands to ODrives (via CAN-FD)
- Pi sends angle commands to servos (via GPIO PWM)
- ODrives drive flap motors
- Servos move pitch and sweep angles
- Wings move — aircraft flies

3.2 CAN-FD Bus — Connecting the ODrives

CAN-FD (Controller Area Network, Flexible Data rate) is a two-wire communication bus. All four ODrives share a single pair of wires (CAN-H and CAN-L) running in a daisy-chain from the Pi to ODrive 1, then to ODrive 2, then ODrive 3, then ODrive 4.

Wires needed	Twisted pair, 24AWG minimum. Use CAT5 ethernet cable — it is already twisted.
Pi CAN interface	MCP2515 CAN hat for Raspberry Pi, or a USB-to-CAN adapter (PCAN-USB or similar).
ODrive CAN pins	Labelled CAN-H and CAN-L on each ODrive. Connect H to H and L to L throughout the chain.
Termination resistors	120 ohm resistors at BOTH ends of the CAN chain. The Pi end and the last ODrive end. Without these the signal reflects and communication fails. Most CAN hats have a built-in termination jumper.
ODrive CAN IDs	Each ODrive must have a unique CAN node ID. Set via ODrive Tool software before installation. IDs 0, 1, 2, 3 for the four units.
CAN speed	Set to 1000000 (1 Mbit/s) on all devices including the Pi CAN interface.

■ CAN-FD is robust and noise-resistant. If communication seems intermittent, check the termination resistors first — this is the most common cause of CAN problems.

3.3 Servo Connections to Raspberry Pi GPIO

The Raspberry Pi communicates with servos via GPIO (General Purpose Input Output) pins. Each servo needs one signal wire connected to a specific GPIO pin on the Pi. All servos also need power (7.4V for pitch servos, 5-6V for sweep servos) and ground — these come from a separate BEC (Battery Eliminator Circuit), not from the Pi.

■ **Never connect servo power (7.4V) to the Pi GPIO pins. GPIO pins are 3.3V signal only. Power goes to the servo rail separately.**

Pitch Servo Pin Assignments (GPIO BCM numbering):

Wing 1 Port (W1p)	GPIO 18
Wing 1 Starboard (W1s)	GPIO 23
Wing 2 Port (W2p)	GPIO 24
Wing 2 Starboard (W2s)	GPIO 25
Wing 3 Port (W3p)	GPIO 12
Wing 3 Starboard (W3s)	GPIO 16
Wing 4 Port (W4p)	GPIO 20
Wing 4 Starboard (W4s)	GPIO 21

Sweep Servo Pin Assignments:

Wing 1 Port sweep	GPIO 4
Wing 1 Starboard sweep	GPIO 17
Wing 2 Port sweep	GPIO 27
Wing 2 Starboard sweep	GPIO 22
Wing 3 Port sweep	GPIO 5
Wing 3 Starboard sweep	GPIO 6
Wing 4 Port sweep	GPIO 13
Wing 4 Starboard sweep	GPIO 19

■ BCM (Broadcom) numbering is used — NOT physical pin numbers. BCM 18 is physical pin 12. Always verify with a Pi GPIO pinout diagram before connecting.

3.4 Load Cell (HX711) to Pi

HX711 DT (Data)	Pi GPIO 26 (physical pin 37)

HX711 SCK (Clock)	Pi GPIO 7 (physical pin 26)
HX711 VCC	Pi 3.3V (physical pin 1 or 17)
HX711 GND	Pi GND (physical pin 9, 25, or 39)
Load cell wires	4-wire load cell: Red=Excitation+, Black=Excitation-, White=Signal+, Green=Signal-. Connect to matching HX711 terminals.

3.5 Pixhawk to Raspberry Pi

Connection type	Serial UART (TELEM2 port on Pixhawk)
Pi side	GPIO 14 (TXD) and GPIO 15 (RXD) — the Pi's hardware serial port, or a USB serial adapter
Pixhawk TELEM2	6-pin JST-GH connector. Pin 2 = TX (connects to Pi RX). Pin 3 = RX (connects to Pi TX). Pin 6 = GND (connects to Pi GND). TX and RX always cross: Pixhawk TX → Pi RX.
Baud rate	921600 baud. Set in both Mission Planner (Pixhawk) and the Wave Library.
Power	Do NOT power the Pi from the Pixhawk or vice versa. Each has its own regulated supply.

3.6 Laptop to Raspberry Pi (Ground Station)

Cable	Standard ethernet cable (Cat5e or Cat6), any length. No crossover cable needed — modern network adapters auto-negotiate.
Pi IP address	192.168.7.1 (set as static)
Laptop IP address	192.168.7.2 (set as static)
Port	5760 (TCP). The ground station server listens on this port.
No router needed	This is a direct point-to-point connection. No WiFi, no router, no internet required.

■ A direct ethernet cable is strongly preferred over WiFi for TC-02 and TC-03. Motor electrical noise can interfere with WiFi and cause dropouts at the worst possible moment.

3.7 Power Distribution

The battery connects to a power distribution board (PDB). From the PDB:

- ODrives: direct 4S LiPo voltage (14.8V). Each ODrive has its own XT30 or XT60 connector.
- Pitch servos: 7.4V regulated BEC. The Helidirect TCM-1001 servos require 7.4V.
- Sweep servos: 5-6V regulated BEC.

- Raspberry Pi: 5V, 3A regulated supply. USB-C connection. Use a quality regulated supply — the Pi is sensitive to voltage fluctuations.
- Pixhawk: 5V from the Pixhawk power module, which also measures battery voltage and current.

■ Connect the battery LAST after all other wiring is complete and verified. Disconnect the battery FIRST before any wiring changes.

SECTION 4 — SOFTWARE — WHAT IT IS AND HOW IT WORKS

4.1 The Three Software Components

There are three pieces of software in this system. They run on different computers and do different things.

Wave Library (mco_wave_library.py)	Runs on the Raspberry Pi. This is the main brain — 24,000+ lines of Python that control every aspect of flight. Reads sensors, computes wing commands, runs the optimizers, manages all safety systems. This is what we have been building throughout this project.
Ground Station (mco_ground_station.py)	Runs on the laptop. A terminal application that connects to the Pi over ethernet and shows you live data from the aircraft. Lets you send commands to the Pi, monitor test progress, and control the optimizer.
Pixhawk Firmware (ArduPilot or PX4)	Runs on the Pixhawk autopilot board. Pre-built firmware — you do not write this code. It provides sensor data (IMU, GPS, barometer) to the Pi via MAVLink protocol.

4.2 What the Wave Library Does

The Wave Library runs a continuous loop — called a "tick" — 50 times per second (every 20 milliseconds). Each tick it:

- Reads all sensor data from the Pixhawk (attitude, airspeed, altitude, GPS position)
- Reads load cell force measurement (during tests)
- Reads pilot control inputs (lever, stick, rudder)
- Runs safety checks (stall speed, never-exceed speed, ground clearance)
- Computes the optimal wing configuration for the current flight condition
- Runs the adaptive optimizers (Loops 1-7) that improve performance over time
- Sends position commands to the ODrives
- Sends angle commands to the pitch and sweep servos
- Sends telemetry to the ground station laptop

This cycle repeats 50 times every second, continuously, for the entire duration of flight.

4.3 The Optimizer System

The Wave Library contains seven adaptive optimizer loops (Loop 1 through Loop 7). These are learning systems that observe how the aircraft is performing and make small adjustments to improve it over time. They do not change anything dramatically — they make tiny, measured changes and observe the result, like a pilot making a series of small trim adjustments. The optimizers improve the aircraft's performance with every flight.

Loop 1 (Stroke level)	Runs every wing stroke. Adjusts the angle of attack (AoA) on the downstroke and upstroke to maximise lift efficiency.
Loop 2 (Cascade phase)	Runs every 2 seconds. Adjusts the timing offset between wing pairs to recover energy from the wake of the front pair (like a coaxial helicopter recovering swirl).
Loop 3 (Surge)	Runs every 5 seconds. Adjusts how the force is distributed between front and rear wing pairs.
Loop 4 (Banked config)	Runs every 12 seconds during banked flight. Adjusts the split-stroke geometry for knife-edge and banked turns.
Loop 5 (Yaw modality)	Runs every 15 seconds. Discovers the best combination of crab, dart, split-stroke, and proverse yaw for efficient turning.
Loop 6 (Lever map)	Runs every 30 seconds. Evaluates whether any discovered wing configurations outperform the current lever zone assignments and proposes remaps.
Loop 7 (Lever feel)	Runs every 45 seconds. Adjusts the sensitivity of the wave lever to minimise how often the pilot needs to make a correction — making the aircraft feel predictable and smooth.

SECTION 5 — SETTING UP THE RASPBERRY PI

5.1 Install the Operating System

The Raspberry Pi needs a Linux operating system. We use Raspberry Pi OS (formerly called Raspbian). This is a free download. Follow these steps exactly.

Step 1 — Download Raspberry Pi Imager:

- Go to: https://www.raspberrypi.com/software/
- Download the Imager for your laptop's operating system (Windows, Mac, or Linux).
- Install and open the Imager application.

Step 2 — Flash the MicroSD card:

- Insert the MicroSD card into your laptop (use an adapter if needed).
- In Raspberry Pi Imager: Choose Device: Raspberry Pi 4 (or your model). Choose OS: Raspberry Pi OS (64-bit). Choose Storage: your MicroSD card.
- Click the gear icon (settings) before writing. Set hostname: mco-1d. Enable SSH. Set username: pi. Set password: choose something memorable. Configure WiFi if you want it (optional).
- Click Write. Wait for it to complete (5-15 minutes).
- Remove the MicroSD and insert it into the Pi.

Step 3 — First boot:

- Connect the Pi to a monitor, keyboard, and mouse (only needed for first setup).
- Connect power. The Pi will boot in 1-2 minutes.
- If you set up SSH, you can also connect from your laptop using: ssh pi@mco-1d.local

5.2 Configure Static IP Address

The Pi needs a fixed (static) IP address so the laptop can always find it at the same address regardless of which network it is on.

Open a terminal on the Pi (or SSH in) and run:

```
sudo nano /etc/dhcpcd.conf
```

Scroll to the bottom of the file and add these lines:

```
interface eth0 static ip_address=192.168.7.1/24 static routers=192.168.7.1 static
domain_name_servers=8.8.8.8
```

Save with Ctrl+X, then Y, then Enter. Reboot:

```
sudo reboot
```

After reboot, verify with:

```
ip addr show eth0
```

You should see 192.168.7.1 in the output.

5.3 Install Required Python Packages

The Wave Library needs a few Python packages. Run these commands in the Pi terminal:

```
sudo apt update sudo apt install python3-pip python3-rpi.gpio -y pip3 install pigpio smbus2 numpy --break-system-packages
```

Start the pigpio daemon (needed for servo PWM):

```
sudo systemctl enable pigpiod sudo systemctl start pigpiod
```

Verify pigpio is running:

```
sudo systemctl status pigpiod
```

You should see "active (running)" in green.

5.4 Install Python CAN Library

The Wave Library communicates with the ODrives over CAN-FD. Install the CAN library:

```
pip3 install python-can odrive --break-system-packages
```

Enable the SPI interface (needed for the MCP2515 CAN hat):

```
sudo raspi-config
```

Navigate to: Interface Options → SPI → Enable. Then reboot.

SECTION 6 — LOADING THE WAVE LIBRARY ONTO THE PI

6.1 Transfer the Files

You need to copy two files from your development computer to the Raspberry Pi:

- mco_wave_library.py — the main flight software
- mco_ground_station.py — the ground station client (this actually runs on the laptop, but keep a copy on the Pi too)

Method 1 — Using SCP (secure copy) over the network:

```
# Run this on your laptop, not the Pi scp mco_wave_library.py pi@192.168.7.1:~/ scp
mco_ground_station.py pi@192.168.7.1:~/
```

Method 2 — Using a USB drive:

- Copy files to a USB drive on your laptop.
- Plug the USB drive into the Pi.
- On the Pi: sudo cp /media/pi/USBDRIVE/mco_wave_library.py ~/

6.2 Verify the Library Loads

SSH into the Pi and run:

```
cd ~ python3 -c "import mco_wave_library as w; print('Library OK')"
```

If you see "Library OK" the file loaded without errors. If you see error messages, check that all required packages from Section 5.3 are installed.

6.3 How to Interact with the Library

The Wave Library is a Python module. You interact with it by writing short Python scripts that import it, or by typing commands in the Python interactive interpreter. During TC-02 and TC-03 you will use pre-written test scripts.

To start an interactive session on the Pi:

```
python3 >>> import mco_wave_library as w >>> w.gs_start() # starts ground station server
>>> w.gnd_clear_status() # shows ground clearance status >>> exit() # to quit
```

The most important functions during testing are:

w.gs_start()	Start the ground station TCP server. Call this first — it lets the laptop connect.
w.aero_cal_status()	Show aerodynamic calibration status. How many observations have been collected.
w.lm6_zone_report()	Show the current lever zone map and any pending remap candidates.

w.violent_manoeuvre_status()	Show which safety systems are currently active.
w.l7_status()	Show the lever feel optimizer — how smooth the lever feels and how it is being tuned.

6.4 The TC-02 Test Script

Create a file on the Pi called run_tc02.py:

```
import mco_wave_library as w # Start ground station so laptop can monitor w.gs_start() # Connect hardware (adjust these for your setup) import pigpio pi = pigpio.pi() # Run the static thrust test # Parameters: pigpio instance, ODrive axes list, # load cell reader, output CSV path results = w.tc02_static_thrust_test( pi_handle=pi, odrive_axes=None, # replace with actual axes loadcell=None, # replace with HX711 reader ) # Feed results into calibration system w.tc02_feed_calibration(results['results']) w.aero_cal_status() pi.stop()
```

Run it with:

```
python3 run_tc02.py
```

SECTION 7 — SETTING UP THE LAPTOP GROUND STATION

7.1 What the Ground Station Shows

The ground station application (mco_ground_station.py) runs on your laptop and shows a live display of everything happening on the Pi. It refreshes automatically every half second. You can also type commands to send to the Pi.

The display is divided into panels:

- **Flight State:** airspeed, height, specific excess power (Ps — positive means climbing, negative means descending), bank angle, flap frequency, lever position. Also shows which systems are currently active.
- **TC-02/TC-03 Data:** each test point displayed the instant the load cell reading completes. Shows lift force in Newtons, CT (thrust coefficient), and whether T/W (thrust-to-weight) exceeds 1.0.
- **Lever Zone Map:** current zone assignments and any modes the optimizer is proposing to add.
- **Command prompt:** type commands here to control the Pi remotely.

7.2 Configure the Laptop Static IP

The laptop needs a static IP on the same subnet as the Pi (192.168.7.x).

On macOS:

- System Settings → Network
- Select your ethernet adapter (or USB ethernet)
- Click Details
- TCP/IP tab → Configure IPv4: Manually
- IP Address: 192.168.7.2
- Subnet Mask: 255.255.255.0
- Router: (leave blank)
- Click OK and Apply

On Linux:

```
sudo ip addr add 192.168.7.2/24 dev eth0 # Replace eth0 with your actual interface name #
Find it with: ip link show
```

On Windows:

- Control Panel → Network and Internet → Network Connections
- Right-click your ethernet adapter → Properties
- Select "Internet Protocol Version 4 (TCP/IPv4)" → Properties
- Select "Use the following IP address"
- IP: 192.168.7.2 Subnet: 255.255.255.0 Gateway: (blank)
- Click OK

7.3 Verify the Connection

With the ethernet cable connected and both IPs set, test from the laptop:

```
ping 192.168.7.1
```

You should see responses like "64 bytes from 192.168.7.1". If you see "Request timeout" or "No route to host", check: cable connected, Pi is on, IP addresses correct.

7.4 Install Python on the Laptop

Check if Python 3.8+ is already installed:

```
python3 --version
```

If you see Python 3.8 or higher, you are ready. If not, or if python3 is not found:

- Mac: Install from https://www.python.org/downloads/ or use Homebrew: brew install python3
- Linux: sudo apt install python3
- Windows: Download from https://www.python.org/downloads/ and run the installer. Check "Add to PATH".

7.5 Run the Ground Station

Copy mco_ground_station.py to your laptop. Then, with the Pi running and gs_start() called on the Pi:

```
python3 mco_ground_station.py 192.168.7.1
```

You will see "Connected." and the display will appear. The command prompt shows "mco>" where you type commands.

Essential commands to know:

status	Full telemetry snapshot from the Pi
aero	Aerodynamic calibration detail — shows what has been measured so far
zones	Lever zone map — shows which wing modes are assigned to which lever positions
freeze	Freeze all optimizer loops — use before changing any settings manually
restore	Unfreeze optimizer loops after changes
set KEY value	Change a setting on the Pi. Example: set WFAOA_GAIN 0.8 set LM6_AUTO_REMAP true
remap ZONE	Confirm a pending lever zone remap. Example: remap SPRINT
abort	Stop a TC-02 or TC-03 test immediately
help	Show all available commands

q	Quit the ground station

SECTION 8 — ODRIVE CONFIGURATION — STEP BY STEP

■ This section requires ODrive Tool software on your laptop and a USB connection to each ODrive one at a time. Do NOT connect the ODrives to the CAN bus until they are individually configured.

8.1 Install ODrive Tool on Laptop

```
pip3 install odrive
```

Verify:

```
odrivetool --version
```

8.2 Connect One ODrive at a Time

Take the first ODrive. Connect only:

- USB cable from ODrive to laptop
- Power supply to ODrive (use bench supply set to 14.8V, limit 2A for configuration — NOT the main battery)
- One motor connected (motor 0 or 1)

Do NOT connect the CAN bus yet.

```
odrivetool
```

You will see "Connected to ODrive..." and a prompt showing the firmware version.

8.3 Configure Each ODrive

In the ODrive Tool prompt, type these commands one by one. Press Enter after each.

Set CAN node ID (use 0 for first ODrive, 1 for second, 2 for third, 3 for fourth):

```
odrv0.can.config.node_id = 0 odrv0.can.config.baud_rate = 1000000
```

Configure motor (do this for both axis0 and axis1):

```
odrv0.axis0.motor.config.pole_pairs = 7
odrv0.axis0.motor.config.resistance_calib_max_voltage = 4
odrv0.axis0.motor.config.requested_current_range = 25
odrv0.axis0.motor.config.current_control_bandwidth = 100
odrv0.axis0.motor.config.motor_type = MOTOR_TYPE_HIGH_CURRENT
```

Set velocity limit — THIS IS CRITICAL:

```
odrv0.axis0.controller.config.vel_limit = 150 odrv0.axis1.controller.config.vel_limit =
150
```

■ The vel_limit MUST be set to 150 rad/s. The factory default is much lower and will prevent the wings from reaching the necessary flapping frequency. Without this change the aircraft cannot generate enough thrust to fly.

Set control mode to position control:

```
odrv0.axis0.controller.config.control_mode = CONTROL_MODE_POSITION_CONTROL
odrv0.axis0.controller.config.input_mode = INPUT_MODE_POS_FILTER
odrv0.axis1.controller.config.control_mode = CONTROL_MODE_POSITION_CONTROL
odrv0.axis1.controller.config.input_mode = INPUT_MODE_POS_FILTER
```

Configure encoder (hall effect sensors):

```
odrv0.axis0.encoder.config.mode = ENCODER_MODE_HALL odrv0.axis0.encoder.config.cpr = 42
odrv0.axis1.encoder.config.mode = ENCODER_MODE_HALL odrv0.axis1.encoder.config.cpr = 42
```

Save and reboot:

```
odrv0.save_configuration() odrv0.reboot()
```

Repeat for all four ODrives, changing the node_id to 1, 2, 3 for each subsequent unit.

8.4 Calibrate Each Motor

With one ODrive powered (bench supply) and one motor connected, run motor calibration:

```
odrv0.axis0.requested_state = AXIS_STATE_MOTOR_CALIBRATION
```

The motor will beep and make a short movement. Wait until it stops. Check for errors:

```
odrv0.axis0.motor.error
```

If the result is 0, calibration succeeded. If non-zero, check motor connections and power supply.

Then calibrate the encoder:

```
odrv0.axis0.requested_state = AXIS_STATE_ENCODER_HALL_POLARITY_CALIBRATION
```

Wait for completion, then:

```
odrv0.axis0.requested_state = AXIS_STATE_ENCODER_OFFSET_CALIBRATION
```

Save the calibration:

```
odrv0.axis0.config.startup_encoder_offset_calibration = True odrv0.save_configuration()
```

■ The calibration only needs to be done once per motor. If you replace a motor, repeat calibration for that channel.

SECTION 9 — PIXHAWK CONFIGURATION — STEP BY STEP

9.1 Install Mission Planner on Laptop

Mission Planner is the configuration software for the Pixhawk. Download from:

```
https://ardupilot.org/planner/docs/mission-planner-installation.html
```

Alternatively, use QGroundControl from:

```
https://docs.qgroundcontrol.com/master/en/getting_started/download_and_install.html
```

Either works. This manual uses Mission Planner examples.

9.2 Flash ArduPilot Firmware

- Connect Pixhawk to laptop via USB.
- Open Mission Planner.
- Go to Setup → Install Firmware.
- Select your vehicle type. For the MCO-1D select "ArduPlane" — closest to our fixed-wing-like control structure.
- Click the appropriate firmware version and wait for installation to complete.
- The Pixhawk will reboot with new firmware.

9.3 Key Parameter Settings

In Mission Planner, go to Config → Full Parameter List. Set these parameters:

SERIAL2_BAUD	921 (= 921600 baud — connection to Pi)
SERIAL2_PROTOCOL	2 (MAVLink 2)
ARSPD_TYPE	1 (analog airspeed sensor) or 0 if using pitot tube with digital output
COMPASS_ENABLE	1 (enable magnetometer)
INS_GYRO_FILTER	20 (gyroscope filter)
AHRS_EKF_TYPE	3 (EKF3 — best for this application)

After setting parameters, click Write Params to save to the Pixhawk.

9.4 Sensor Calibration

In Mission Planner, go to Setup → Mandatory Hardware:

- **Accelerometer Calibration:** Follow the on-screen instructions to hold the Pixhawk in 6 orientations. This calibrates the accelerometer so the IMU knows which way is up.

- **Compass Calibration:** Click Start, rotate the Pixhawk through all orientations slowly. Complete when the progress bar reaches 100%.
- **Radio Calibration:** If using an RC transmitter, move all sticks to their extremes while watching the bar graphs to set the minimum and maximum values.
- **Level Calibration:** Place the Pixhawk level on a flat surface and click Calibrate Level.

SECTION 10 — SERVO CONFIGURATION AND CALIBRATION

10.1 What Calibration Achieves

Servo calibration tells the Wave Library exactly how to convert a commanded angle (in degrees) into a pulse-width signal (in microseconds) for each specific servo. Because servos vary slightly from unit to unit, each of the 16 servos (8 pitch, 8 sweep) must be calibrated individually.

10.2 Pitch Servo Calibration

With the Pi running and servos powered (7.4V BEC), run the calibration function. SSH into the Pi and:

```
python3 >>> import mco_wave_library as w >>> import pigpio >>> pi = pigpio.pi() >>> #
Calibrate wing 1 port pitch servo (index 0) >>> w.pitch_servo_calibrate(pi, wing_index=0)
>>> # Repeat for indices 1 through 7
```

The calibration procedure for each servo:

- The servo moves to the neutral position (1500 microseconds). Observe that the wing is at 0 degrees angle of attack (chord horizontal, aligned with the wing span).
- The function then commands known angles and asks you to confirm or adjust until the physical angle matches the commanded angle.
- Results are stored in the library automatically.

10.3 Direction Verification

After calibration, run the direction verification:

```
>>> w.direction_verify(pi)
```

This commands each wing to move in a specific direction and asks you to confirm it moved the right way. If a wing moves backwards, the servo direction for that wing is reversed in the library automatically.

10.4 Startup Self-Check

Run the startup check to verify all systems:

```
>>> w.mco_startup_check(pi) # This checks all servos, CAN communications, # load cell (if
connected), and sensor readings. # Fix any reported errors before proceeding.
```

SECTION 11 — TC-02 STATIC THRUST TEST — COMPLETE PROCEDURE

11.1 What TC-02 Measures

TC-02 (Test Condition 02) is the static thrust test. "Static" means the aircraft is not moving — it is attached to a test rig and the wings flap while we measure the upward force they produce. This answers the fundamental question: can this aircraft carry its own weight?

The key number is CT — the Thrust Coefficient. This is a dimensionless number that characterises how efficiently the wings produce force. If CT multiplied by the dynamic conditions equals a force greater than the aircraft weight (34N), the aircraft can hover. If not, it needs forward speed to fly.

11.2 Test Rig Setup

Before any electronics are connected:

- Mount the aircraft rigidly to a sturdy test stand. The aircraft must not move during the test — any movement will corrupt the force readings.
- Mount the load cell between the aircraft and the test stand. The cell should be in line with the expected thrust direction (vertically, below the aircraft, so upward thrust compresses or stretches the cell depending on mounting).
- Ensure the wings have clear space to flap — at least 1 metre clearance in all directions.
- Keep all cables (power, CAN, servo signal) clear of the wing paths.

■ During TC-02 the wings flap at up to 3 Hz with 96 degrees of amplitude. Keep hands, tools, and other objects away from the wing paths at all times when the test is running.

11.3 Electronics Connection for TC-02

- Connect load cell to HX711 module.
- Connect HX711 to Pi GPIO (Section 3.4).
- Connect ODrives to CAN bus.
- Connect all 8 pitch servos to GPIO (Section 3.3).
- Connect servo power (7.4V BEC).
- Connect ethernet cable: Pi to laptop.
- Connect main battery LAST.

11.4 Starting the Test

Step 1 — Start ground station on Pi:

```
ssh pi@192.168.7.1 python3 >>> import mco_wave_library as w >>> w.gs_start()
```

Step 2 — Connect laptop ground station:

```
# On laptop python3 mco_ground_station.py 192.168.7.1
```

You should see "Connected" and the live display appears.

Step 3 — Run startup check:

```
# On Pi >>> w.mco_startup_check(pi) # Fix any errors before continuing
```

Step 4 — Run TC-02:

```
>>> results = w.tc02_static_thrust_test( ... pi_handle=pi, ... odrive_axes=axes, # your
ODrive axis list ... loadcell=lc, # your HX711 reader object ... )
```

The test runs automatically. On the laptop you will see each test point appear as it completes — frequency, amplitude, cascade phase, lift force, and CT.

11.5 What to Watch on the Laptop During TC-02

On the ground station display, watch the TC-02 Data panel. For each test point you will see:

Lift N	Force in Newtons. Aircraft weight is 33.8N. If any point shows lift > 33.8N, the aircraft can generate enough thrust to support itself.
CT	Thrust coefficient. Higher is better. Values above 0.20 indicate good thrust performance.
T/W	Thrust-to-weight ratio. Green tick = above 1.0 = more thrust than weight. This is the goal.
Profile	Which wing pitch profile was used — slow (32° AoA), cruise (22°), or climb (28°).

11.6 After TC-02 Completes

The results are automatically fed into the aerodynamic calibration system. Check the updated model:

```
# On laptop ground station mco> aero
```

You will see the updated values for CL_MAX, peak AoA, efficiency AoA, and Vs (stall speed). These values now reflect what the actual aircraft produces, not just what the aerodynamic models predicted.

The TC-02 sweep test also runs automatically after the main test — this tests different wing sweep angles and dihedral combinations to validate the glide polar model.

If TC-02 shows T/W < 1.0 at all conditions:

- The aircraft cannot hover in free air in the conventional sense.
- Forward flight is still possible — the aircraft needs airspeed to generate enough lift.
- The STOL and inclined stroke plane modes may still provide near-hover capability — this is tested in TC-03 with the aircraft pitched at 52 degrees nose-up.
- Do not be discouraged — many successful ornithopters do not hover and are still highly capable aircraft.

SECTION 12 — TC-03 DYNAMIC THRUST TEST — COMPLETE PROCEDURE

12.1 What TC-03 Measures

TC-03 measures how the thrust changes as the aircraft moves forward through the air. In TC-02 the aircraft was stationary. In TC-03 it moves at different speeds (typically 0 to 15 m/s in increments). This produces the CT-J curve — a graph showing how thrust coefficient (CT) varies with advance ratio (J). J is the ratio of forward speed to wing-tip speed. When J is low (slow forward speed, fast wings) efficiency is high. As J increases (faster forward flight) the thrust coefficient typically decreases.

TC-03 is usually done by mounting the aircraft on a vehicle (car or cart) and driving at different speeds while measuring force. An alternative is a wind tunnel if one is available.

12.2 TC-03 Procedure Summary

- Mount aircraft on vehicle with load cell, same as TC-02 but on a moving vehicle.
- Drive at each test speed (2, 4, 6, 8, 10, 12, 15 m/s) and hold steady for at least 10 seconds.
- The load cell records force at each speed.
- Results automatically feed into the stroke plane controller model.

```
>>> results = w.tc03_dynamic_thrust_test( ... pi_handle=pi, ... odrive_axes=axes, ...
loadcell=lc, ... pitot_fn=pitot_reader, # function returning m/s ... )
```

After TC-03, the full aerodynamic model is calibrated to this specific aircraft at its actual weight and with its actual wings. All optimizer loops now have accurate baseline data.

SECTION 13 — FIRST FREE FLIGHT — CHECKLIST AND PROCEDURE

■ Do not attempt free flight until TC-02 and TC-03 are complete and all calibrations have been verified. Do not fly in winds above 5 m/s for first flights. Always fly in a clear open area well away from people.

13.1 Pre-Flight Checklist

Complete every item before each flight. Sign off each:

■ Battery voltage	> 15.0V (fully charged = 16.8V)
■ All servo connections	Verified, not loose
■ CAN bus connections	Verified, terminators in place
■ Wing hinges	Free movement, no binding
■ Rope/capstan tension	Correct — not slack, not overtight
■ Load cell removed	Test rig disconnected for free flight
■ Pixhawk GPS lock	At least 8 satellites, HDOP < 2.0
■ Startup check passed	w.mco_startup_check() — all green
■ Ground station connected	Laptop shows live telemetry
■ Area clear	No people within 30 metres

13.2 First Flight Sequence

Flight 1 should be the minimum possible to verify basic controllability. Approximately 30-60 seconds.

- **Low hover/taxi test:** With the wave lever at approximately 50% (trim), advance slowly and observe whether the aircraft lifts off. If it does not lift off, this confirms forward flight is required and you proceed to a takeoff run.
- **First takeoff:** Advance the wave lever toward 60-70%. The aircraft should begin to lift. Allow it to climb to approximately 5 metres AGL. Do not attempt any manoeuvres.
- **Level flight check:** Find the lever position where the aircraft flies level (Ps near zero on the ground station). This confirms the trim point.
- **Landing:** Reduce lever slowly. As airspeed drops below 6.3 m/s the STOL back-side controller activates (shown on ground station). Use the lever to control descent rate. Land gently with lever at minimum.

13.3 Polar Survey (First Flight)

Once the aircraft is confirmed flyable and stable, start the autonomous polar survey on the second flight at a safe height (minimum 30 metres AGL):

```
# On laptop ground station mco> survey 35
```

The aircraft will automatically run through its test sequence — approximately 12 minutes. Do not intervene unless there is a safety issue. The survey updates all aerodynamic model constants from actual flight data.

SECTION 14 — WHAT THE OPTIMIZER IS DOING AND HOW TO READ IT

14.1 Understanding the Optimizer Display

The ground station shows optimizer status at all times. Here is what each indicator means:

Ps (Specific Excess Power)	The most important single number. Positive Ps means the aircraft has more thrust than needed to maintain level flight — it is gaining energy. Negative means it is losing energy. At trim, Ps is near zero. Unit: metres per second.
L1-L4 frozen	If any loop shows "frozen" it means a safety event has stopped the optimizer from changing anything. This is correct behaviour during violent manoeuvres. The optimizers resume automatically when safe.
Discovery ON/OFF	When ON, the aircraft is actively experimenting with new wing configurations. This is safe — the safety limits always apply even during discovery. The aircraft will not try configurations that could cause a stall or structural damage.
L6 candidates	The number of lever zone remap proposals the system has accumulated. When this is > 0, the system has found a better mode for one or more lever zones. Type "zones" in the ground station to see details and "remap ZONE" to confirm.
corr/min (Loop 7)	Lever correction frequency — how often the pilot makes a direction reversal on the lever. Lower is better. Target is below 2 corrections per minute. As Loop 7 learns, this should decrease over flights.

14.2 What Normal Looks Like

During a normal stable flight you expect to see:

- Ps between -0.1 and +0.3 during level flight
- All loops running (not frozen)
- Discovery OFF unless you have explicitly enabled it
- corr/min below 3
- CL_MAX and Vs values close to the TC-02 measurements

14.3 When to Intervene

Only intervene in the optimizer if you see:

- Ps consistently very negative (below -1.0) during level flight — indicates something is wrong with the calibration or the aircraft is too heavy.
- L6 proposing to retire a mode you use regularly — inspect the proposal before confirming.
- Discovery mode finding highly unusual configurations — inspect before locking them in.

In all other cases, let the optimizer run. It is improving the aircraft with each flight.

SECTION 15 — EMERGENCY PROCEDURES

■ These procedures must be memorised before first flight. In an emergency there is no time to look them up.

15.1 Loss of Control

- Move wave lever to minimum immediately.
- Level the wings with the roll stick.
- Allow the aircraft to descend and land.
- Do not attempt to recover from unusual attitudes below 15 metres AGL.

15.2 Runaway Aircraft (radio link lost)

The RC watchdog will automatically activate if radio signal is lost for more than 1.5 seconds. The aircraft will enter Return to Home mode and fly back to the launch point at 15 metres altitude, then descend and land.

If the RTH appears to be malfunctioning:

- The aircraft will land automatically after RTH_LAND_TIMEOUT seconds (default 30).
- Stand clear of the landing area.

15.3 Fire / Battery Damage

- Do not touch a burning LiPo battery.
- Use a Class D fire extinguisher (dry sand also works).
- Do not use water on a LiPo fire.
- Evacuate the area — LiPo fires produce toxic fumes.

15.4 Abort TC-02 or TC-03 Test

To immediately stop a running test from the laptop:

```
mco> abort
```

Or from the Pi terminal: Ctrl+C in the test script.

To cut power immediately: disconnect the battery.

SECTION 16 — GLOSSARY — EVERY TECHNICAL TERM EXPLAINED

AoA (Angle of Attack)	The angle between the wing chord (a line from leading edge to trailing edge) and the direction of airflow. Higher AoA = more lift, up to a limit (stall).
Advance Ratio (J)	Forward speed divided by wing-tip speed. J=0 means hovering. Higher J = faster forward flight.
Baud rate	Speed of serial communication, measured in bits per second. 921600 baud = 921,600 bits per second.
BEC (Battery Eliminator Circuit)	A voltage regulator that converts the main battery voltage (14.8V) to a lower regulated voltage (5V or 7.4V) for servos and electronics.
Boyd Cruise	The most efficient forward flight mode. Named after John Boyd (OODA loop creator) whose energy maneuver theory underlies the flight software's energy management.
CAN-FD	Controller Area Network Flexible Data rate. A high-speed two-wire serial bus used to communicate with the ODrives. Robust against electrical noise.
Cascade Phase	The timing offset between consecutive wing pairs. Optimal phase allows each pair to recover energy from the wake of the pair ahead.
CF1 (Clap-and-Fling)	A wing motion technique where the wings come very close together at the top or bottom of each stroke, then fling apart. Produces extra lift through vortex enhancement. Used at low speeds for maximum thrust.
CT (Thrust Coefficient)	A dimensionless number that characterises thrust efficiency. Higher CT = more efficient thrust production.
Dihedral	The upward angle of the wings relative to horizontal. Positive dihedral (tips higher than roots) gives stability. Negative dihedral (anhedral) aids maneuverability.
GEF (Ground Effect Flight)	When an aircraft flies within one wingspan of the ground, the downwash is disrupted and lift increases. The MCO uses this zone deliberately for efficient low-altitude operations.
GPIO	General Purpose Input Output. The 40 programmable pins on the Raspberry Pi used to control servos and read sensors.
HX711	A small amplifier chip that reads load cell signals and converts them to digital values the Raspberry Pi can read.
IFR (Instrument Flight Rules)	Rules governing flight in poor visibility using instruments rather than visual references. The MCO is designed to be capable of precise altitude and speed control to IFR standards.

IMU (Inertial Measurement Unit)	Sensors measuring acceleration and rotation. The Pixhawk's IMU tells the flight computer which way the aircraft is pointing and how fast it is rotating.
Lever / Wave Lever	The pilot's primary thrust control. Analogous to the throttle in a conventional aircraft. Controls energy state.
LiPo	Lithium Polymer battery. High energy density. Used in this aircraft for its light weight and high current output. Requires careful handling.
MAVLink	A lightweight communication protocol used between the Pixhawk and the Raspberry Pi to transmit sensor data and commands.
Metachronal Cascade	The timing pattern where each wing pair beats slightly after the previous one. Creates a wave-like motion through the wing pairs. Inspired by dragonfly flight.
ODrive	A high-performance motor controller. Takes position commands from the Pi and drives the flap motors with precise current control.
Pitot Tube	A forward-facing tube that measures airspeed by sensing the difference between total pressure (from the airflow) and static pressure.
Proverse Yaw	When the aircraft turns in the same direction as it banks, unlike the adverse yaw of conventional aircraft. Flapping wings naturally produce proverse yaw, which aids coordinated turns.
Ps (Specific Excess Power)	A measure of whether the aircraft has more power than needed for level flight. Positive Ps = excess power available to climb or accelerate. Negative = deficit.
PWM (Pulse Width Modulation)	The signal format used to control servos. A pulse is sent repeatedly; the width of the pulse (in microseconds) determines the servo position.
Sector Wheel	The disc-shaped mechanical component at each wing root that converts motor rotation into wing flapping. Has 200 degrees of total travel (±100 degrees from centre).
Split Stroke	A configuration where port wings use the bottom half of the flapping arc and starboard wings use the top half. Used for knife-edge flight and banked altitude control.
Stall	The condition where the wing angle of attack exceeds the critical angle and lift suddenly decreases. The MCO stall speed is approximately 4.85 m/s.
STOL (Short Takeoff and Landing)	Flight technique using maximum lift at minimum speed for precision takeoff and landing in short distances.
Stroke Plane	The imaginary flat surface through which the wing tips travel during flapping. Tilting the stroke plane redirects the thrust vector.

T/W (Thrust-to-Weight ratio)	Total thrust divided by aircraft weight. T/W > 1.0 means the aircraft can hover. T/W < 1.0 means it needs forward speed to fly.
Vne (Never Exceed Speed)	The maximum speed the aircraft must never exceed for structural safety reasons. For the MCO-1D: 28 m/s.
Vs (Stall Speed)	The minimum speed at which the aircraft can maintain level flight. Below this speed, conventional lift is insufficient to support the aircraft weight. MCO-1D Vs: approximately 4.85 m/s.
WFAOA (World-Frame Angle of Attack Correction)	A system that adjusts pitch servo commands based on bank angle so the wings always generate upward force regardless of how the aircraft is banked.

End of MCO-1D Commissioning Manual

For questions, corrections, or updates to this document, refer to the programme development log.